

ANALYSIS

TRUMP BASKS IN THE MIDEAST

His ceasefire brings praise from all sides, but the underlying conflict remains.

By MICHAEL WILNER

Summoned last minute by the president of the United States, the world's most powerful leaders dropped their schedules to fly to Egypt on Monday, where they idled on a stage awaiting Donald Trump's grand entrance.

They were there to celebrate a significant U.S. diplomatic achievement that has ended hostilities in Gaza after two brutal years of war. But really, they were there for Trump, who took a victory lap for brokering what he called the "greatest deal of them all."

"Together we've achieved what everyone said was impossible, but at long last, we have peace in the Middle East," Trump told gathered presidents, sheikhs, prime ministers and emirs, arriving in Egypt after addressing the Knesset in Israel. "Nobody thought it could ever get there, and now we're there."

"Now, the rebuilding begins — the rebuilding is maybe going to be the easiest part," Trump said. "I think we've done a lot of the hardest part, because the rest comes together. We all know how to rebuild, and we know how to build better than anybody in the world."

The achievement of a ceasefire in Gaza has earned Trump praise from across the political aisle and from U.S. friends and foes around the world, securing an elusive peace that officials hope will endure long enough to provide space for a wider settlement of Mideast tensions.

Trump's negotiation of the Abraham Accords in his first term, which saw his administration secure diplomatic relations between Israel and the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Sudan and Morocco, were a non-partisan success embraced by the Biden administration. But it was the Oct. 7 attack on Israel, and the over-

[See Trump, A5]



LEO CORREA Associated Press



JEHAD ALSHRAFI Associated Press

IN ISRAEL, Rom Breslavski, top, one of the 20 living hostages freed by Hamas, arrives Monday by helicopter at a medical center in Ramat Gan. In Gaza, some of the more than 1,900 Palestinians released by Israel arrive by bus in Khan Yunis.

Protesters at colleges vow to continue their activism

Other students say they hope to find common ground

By Jaweed Kaleem and Daniel Miller

At California universities Monday, the ceasefire in Gaza — and the accompanying hostage and prisoner exchange — emerged as an inflection point for the future of a student-led protest movement that for two years has roiled campuses.

The activism, along with its contentious aftermath, continues to reverberate as pro-Palestinian organizers and Jewish community leaders reckon with the tumult touched off by Hamas' Oct. 7, 2023, attack on Israel.

For months in 2024 — shortly after the onset of the deadliest and most destructive war between Israelis and Palestinians in history — college campuses in the U.S. convulsed in often confrontational protests. Pro-Palestinian demon-

strations surged in the spring of that year with encampments where activists demanded campus policy changes, including U.S. university divestment of billions of dollars from weapons companies.

On this front, their activism largely foundered. In California, not one major university agreed to full divestment demands, which included boycotts of partnerships with Israeli universities. And campus policies did change — with university officials cracking down on protests and enforcing zero-tolerance policies against rule-breaking.

But David N. Myers, a UCLA professor of Jewish history, said student protesters appear to have helped change American

[See Students, A5]

Homecoming for Israelis, Palestinians

Trump hails release of hostages and prisoners and attends summit about Gaza's future.

By NABIH BULOS

REIM, Israel — Israelis and Palestinians cried, cheered and gave thanks Monday as Hamas militants released their last 20 living hostages in exchange for more than 1,900 Palestinian prisoners and detainees.

It was the first phase of a ceasefire deal put in place last month even as President Trump — the driving force behind the agreement — gave what amounted to a victory speech in the Knesset, the Israeli parliament, before departing for a peace summit in Egypt.

Greeted with a standing ovation before he said a word, Trump heralded the deal as ushering in "a golden age" for Israel and the Middle East.

"After so many years of unceasing war and endless danger, today, the skies are calm, the guns are silent, the sirens are still, and the sun rises on a Holy Land that is finally at peace," he said.

His words belied the many complications facing an agreement that remains far from a comprehensive road map that could definitively end a war that killed tens of thousands of Palestinians and pulverized much of the Gaza Strip, even as it scarred Israeli society with the deaths of 1,200 people and brought unprecedented international condemnation of the country's

leadership.

The night before the scheduled morning hand-over, tens of thousands Israelis streamed into Hostages Square in Tel Aviv, as well as to the roadside near southern Israel's Reim military base, where the hostages were to be brought after their release.

A party atmosphere prevailed on the road to Reim, as Sikorsky Super Stallion helicopters landed on a dusty field to the cheers of a nearby crowd, which raised Israeli and American flags and swayed to a song whose lyrics promised, "I'm coming home, tell the world I'm coming home."

Passing cars honked in salute, with one passenger rolling down her window and shouting, "The kidnapped are returning!"

"Since Thursday my smile has been stuck, my jaw hurts from it, after two years of not doing it at all," said Sarit Kenny, 65, a resident of a kibbutz nearby who said she had attended a rally every week since the Hamas-led attack on Oct. 7, 2023, to call for the hostages' return.

She pointed to the American flag in her hand, saying she wanted it to be an expression of her appreciation of Trump.

"He's the one who actually did this. He did what our prime minister didn't do," she said.

Jonathan Kaneh, 46, who owned a polymer factory in the kibbutz of Orim, saw in the release a more somber moment. On Oct. 7, Hamas militants on a truck shot at him as he was riding his bicycle; the bullet grazed his arm

[See Mideast, A4]



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PRESIDENT Trump, shown with Israeli leader Benjamin Netanyahu, addressed the nation's parliament.

When L.A. police drive badly, victim payouts soar

By LIBOR JANY AND VANESSA MARTÍNEZ

The last memory Richard Paper has from the day of the crash was going for a walk that morning.

The next thing he remembers after that day last summer was waking up in a hospital bed. Weeks had

passed. Only later did he learn that he and his brother Stephen had been badly injured when an LAPD squad broadsided their car as they made a left turn through a San Fernando Valley intersection.

The brothers, both in their mid-70s, sued the city of Los Angeles and the officer who was driving, leading to

an \$18-million settlement last month — thought to be the most city taxpayers have ever paid to resolve a police collision case.

Although lawsuits over police shootings and protest tactics tend to receive the most scrutiny, officer-involved traffic incidents remain an intractable and costly problem. Even before

the Paper brothers' record settlement, the city had spent at least \$90 million in negotiated payouts or verdicts in more than 1,200 lawsuits related to bad police driving over the last decade, according to a Times analysis of public records data. Dozens of other cases that could lead to large payouts remain pending.

At any given moment, scores of police squads are out across the city, rushing to emergency calls for help or cruising around in search of criminal behavior. Despite training on how to speed safely through traffic, more than 500 collisions every year involve LAPD and other law enforcement vehi-

[See LAPD, A14]

After L.A.-area fires, immigrant workers warily carry out cleanups

By COLLEEN SHALBY

Ash still clings to the windowsills of the gray home in Altadena, nine months after an inferno ripped the community apart.

The couple who rents the house has moved 15 times with their newborn since January as their place of solace for the last decade has awaited clearing and remediation to clear it of toxic material and debris.

Help has finally arrived. Wearing white hazmat suits that cover them from head to toe, gloves, respirator masks and goggles, a group of workers enters the residence.

When the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers completed its debris removal in Altadena after January's fire tore through the town, the task to clean what survived didn't stop. Hundreds of smoke-damaged and ash-filled homes remained standing on streets where others burned.

These efforts to clean them have largely been carried out by immigrant workers who have risked not just their health while clearing homes of toxic material and debris but, with ongoing raids, the lives they have built in California.

They meticulously vacuum, and scrub the walls, windows, baseboards and

floors, clearing every open surface and precious possession of reminders of the Eaton fire.

Ricardo Melo has overseen more than 100 cleanups in Altadena and 25 in Pacific Palisades. He works for the National Day Laborer Organizing Network and said those he supervises have emigrated from Mexico, Central America and South America. Despite fears of deportation, his teams have continued to show up.

Melo's approach to the cleanup is two-pronged: The first is ensuring that the workers understand who lived here before the fire — in this case a family with a baby

[See Cleaning, A14]

House speaker predicts a long federal shutdown

Mike Johnson says he "won't negotiate" until Democrats halt health-care battle and reopen government. **NATION, A6**

Chatbot safety bill becomes law

Gov. Gavin Newsom signs legislation requiring AI procedures meant to prevent self-harm. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Rain, a thunderstorm. L.A. Basin: 66/55. **B6**

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Hoping to wave Dodgers home

L.A. and faithful set for Game 1 of NLCS. Go to latimes.com/sports for coverage. **SPORTS, B10**

A SoCal city's bid to combat retail theft

By CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

Tired of rampant shoplifting scaring away citizens and shoppers, Long Beach is trying to force stores to add staff and reduce dependence on self-checkout.

The beachfront city, with a population of around half a million, last month started requiring major food and pharmacy retailers to do more to stop theft. So far, the measures have led to a heated debate and longer lines.

Employees like the new law. The retail chains warn that the restrictions could backfire. Shoppers are confused.

The city's "Safe Stores are Staffed Stores" ordinance is the first of its kind in the country. It requires large stores to increase the number of employees relative to self-checkout stands and also puts a limit on the number of items and types of goods that can be rung up at self-checkout.

[See Theft, A11]